Syllabus

Chevron removed the suit to federal court under the federal officer removal statute, arguing that the suit "relat[ed] to" its contractual duties to refine crude oil into avgas for the military during the war. The District Court rejected this argument and granted the parish's motion to remand to state court. The Fifth Circuit affirmed, agreeing that Chevron had "acted under" a federal officer as a military contractor but concluding that the suit was not "for or relating to" those acts because Chevron's refining contract did not specify how to acquire crude oil. Judge Oldham dissented, reasoning that crude oil was "indispensable" to avgas, such that its production necessarily related to Chevron's performance of its federal avgas refining duties.

Held: Chevron has plausibly alleged a close relationship between its challenged crude-oil production and the performance of its federal avgas refining duties—not a tenuous, remote, or peripheral one—and has therefore satisfied the "relating to" requirement of the federal officer removal statute. Pp. 10–15.

(a) The phrase "relating to" sweeps broadly, meaning "'to stand in some relation; to have bearing or concern; to pertain; refer; to bring into association with or connection with.'" *Morales* v. *Trans World Airlines, Inc.*, 504 U. S. 374, 383. One thing can relate to another even if the connection is "indirect," *Ingersoll-Rand Co.* v. *McClendon*, 498 U. S. 133, 139; even if it was "not specifically designed to affect" it, *ibid.*; and even without a "strict causal relationship," *Ford Motor Co.* v. *Montana Eighth Judicial Dist. Court*, 592 U. S. 351, 362. Accordingly, a removing defendant need not show that his federal duties specifically required or strictly caused the challenged conduct.

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The ordinary meaning of "relating to," however, is not "so broad that it is meaningless." *Rutledge* v. *Pharmaceutical Care Management Assn.*, 592 U. S. 80, 93 (THOMAS, J., concurring). The ordinary meaning requires a connection that is not "'tenuous, remote, or peripheral.'" *Id.*, at 94. Ordinary readers would not understand the federal officer removal statute to reach all suits with any attenuated connection to federal duties. Pp. 11–12.

(b) Chevron's suit "relat[es] to" the performance of federal duties because Chevron has plausibly alleged a close relationship between its challenged conduct and the performance of its federal duties. This suit implicates Chevron's wartime efforts to produce and supply avgas' essential feedstock, so it is closely connected to Chevron's wartime avgas refining for the military. Much of the crude oil that Chevron produced in Plaquemines Parish was ultimately used for its own avgas refining, and the suit challenges Chevron's actions that allowed it to increase its production of crude oil during wartime. The parish's report alleged

that Chevron's use of the coastal zone had been illegally commenced because of its reliance on vertical-drilling methods, canals, and earthen pits—but using vertical-drilling methods maximized crude-oil production; using canals saved time and materials resulting in more timely oil production; and using earthen pits complied with the Government's directive to preserve steel. The Government emphasized the importance of increasing Chevron's crude-oil production to support avgas refining as part of the war effort, and it identified the oil field at issue as critical to the war program because it produced a preferential kind of crude oil for refining avgas. In this all-hands-on-deck, wartime context, Chevron needed to produce more crude oil as quickly as possible to facilitate more avgas refining, including its own. Pp. 12–14.

(c) The Court disagrees with the Fifth Circuit's two main reasons for ruling to the contrary. First, the Fifth Circuit reasoned that Chevron's refining contract did not specify *how* to obtain or produce crude oil, so Chevron's crude-oil production was unrelated to the performance of its federal refining duties. But the ordinary meaning of "relating to" does not require the defendant to show that his federal duties specifically invited his challenged conduct; Chevron's contract did not have to expressly direct or invite Chevron's crude-oil production for that conduct to "relate to" its avgas refining. Second, the Fifth Circuit reasoned that the Government's allocation of crude oil to refineries severed any relation between producing and refining. But an act can relate to its consequences even when the causal chain includes actions by intermediaries, see *Morales*, 504 U. S. 374; producing crude oil relates to refining it into avgas, even if the Government acted as an intermediary allocating the crude oil to refineries. Pp. 14–15.

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(d) The Court also disagrees with Louisiana's argument that the removal statute requires that the defendant was "acting under" a federal officer in taking the specific actions challenged in the suit. This theory is not consistent with the statutory text, which permits removal of suits against officers or their agents for acts that were not done under color of their offices, so long as the suits "relat[e] to" such acts. Louisiana's interpretation would leave the "relating to" requirement with little, if any, independent function, impermissibly conflating the "acting under" and "for or relating to" elements of the federal officer removal test. P. 15.

103 F. 4th 324, vacated and remanded.

THOMAS, J., delivered the opinion of the Court, in which ROBERTS, C. J., and SOTOMAYOR, KAGAN, GORSUCH, KAVANAUGH, and BARRETT, JJ., joined. JACKSON, J., filed an opinion concurring in the judgment, *post*, p. 16. ALITO, J., took no part in the decision of the case.

Counsel

Paul D. Clement argued the cause for petitioners. With him on the briefs were *C. Harker Rhodes IV*, *Joseph J. DeMott*, *Martin A. Stern*, *Jeffrey E. Richardson*, *Robert B. McNeal*, *Kelly B. Becker*, *Jamie D. Rhymes*, *Kannon K. Shanmugam*, *William T. Marks*, *Jennifer J. Clark*, *Alexandra White*, *Eric J. Mayer*, *Charles S. McCowan III*, and *Michael R. Phillips.*

Aaron Z. Roper argued the cause for the United States as *amicus curiae* urging reversal. With him on the briefs were *Solicitor General Sauer*, *Deputy Assistant Attorney General Hamilton*, *Deputy Solicitor General Gannon*, and *Michael S. Raab.*

J. Benjamin Aguiñaga, Solicitor General of Louisiana, argued the cause for respondents. With him on the brief were *Elizabeth B. Murrill*, Attorney General of Louisiana, and *J. Blake Canfield. Victor L. Marcello* filed a brief for respondents Plaquemines Parish et al.*

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*Briefs of *amici curiae* urging reversal were filed for the State of West Virginia et al. by *John B. McCuskey*, Attorney General of West Virginia and *Michael R. Williams*, Solicitor General, and by the Attorneys General for their respective States as follows: *Stephen J. Cox* of Alaska, *Chris Carr* of Georgia, *Brenna Bird* of Iowa, *Catherine Hanaway* of Missouri, *Michael T. Hilgers* of Nebraska, and *Gentner Drummond* of Oklahoma; for the America First Policy Institute by *Nicholas J. Wanic* and *Gina D'Andrea*; for the American Tort Reform Association by *Traci L. Lovitt*; for the Chamber of Commerce of the United States of America et al. by *William M. Jay*, *Andrew Kim*, *Andrew R. Varcoe*, and *Erica Klenicki*; for Express Scripts, Inc., by *Jason R. Scherr* and *Douglas A. Hastings*; for Oil and Gas Associations by *Jason T. Morgan*, *Ryan P. Steen*, *Constance H. Pfeiffer*, and *Andrew T. Ingram*; for the Pelican Institute for Public Policy by *James Baehr* and *Sarah Harbison*; for the Washington Legal Foundation et al. by *Cory L. Andrews* and *Lawrence S. Ebner*; for William P. Barr et al. by *Jeremy B. Rosen* and *John F. Querio*; for Sen. Mike Lee et al. by *Christopher E. Mills* and *Daniel Z. Epstein*; and for General (Ret.) Richard B. Myers et al. by *Tristan L. Duncan*, *William F. Northrip*, and *Cary Silverman.*

Briefs of *amici curiae* urging affirmance were filed for the American Association for Justice et al. by *Robert S. Peck*, *Bruce Plaxen*, *Jeffrey R. White*, *B. Scott Andrews*, and *Stephen J. Herman*; for the Environmental

JUSTICE THOMAS delivered the opinion of the Court.

Congress has long authorized federal officers and their agents to remove suits brought against them in state court to federal court. The federal officer removal statute authorizes an officer or "person acting under that officer" to remove state suits "for or relating to any act under color of such office." 28 U. S. C. § 1442(a)(1). In this case, Chevron USA Inc. invoked the statute to remove to federal court an environmental suit brought against it in Louisiana state court. Chevron argued that the suit was removable because it implicates Chevron's crude-oil production during the Second World War, when Chevron also refined crude oil into aviation gasoline for the U. S. military. No party disputes that Chevron "act[ed] under" federal officers when it performed its refining duties. We thus decide only whether this suit, which implicates Chevron's wartime production of crude oil, "relat[es] to" Chevron's wartime aviation-gasoline refining for the military. We hold that it does.

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To protect the Federal Government from state-court "interference with its operations," Congress has given federal courts jurisdiction over some suits against federal officers or those acting under them. *Watson* v. *Philip Morris Cos.*, 551 U. S. 142, 150 (2007) (internal quotation marks omitted). The current federal officer removal statute traces its lineage to the Force Bill of 1833, which Congress passed to enable federal customs officials to remove suits to federal court after South Carolina began prosecuting them for enforcing

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Defense Fund et al. by *Dana Kaersvang*, *Hyland Hunt*, *Ruthanne M. Deutsch*, *E. Blair Schilling*, *Ian L. Atkinson*, *Isabel A. Englehart*, and *Vickie L. Patton*; for Former Governor John Bel Edwards by *Caroline A. Flynn*; and for General (Ret.) Russel Honoré by *Daniel Woofter* and *Kevin K. Russell*.